

PROJECT SYNOPSIS

Dual-Axis Solar Tracker with Active Cooling System

A Mechatronics Engineering Project

Project Title	Dual-Axis Solar Tracker with Active Cooling System
Department	Mechatronics Engineering
Project Type	Final Year / Semester Project
Academic Year	2025 – 2026
Area of Domain	Renewable Energy, Embedded Systems, Control Systems

1. Introduction

Solar energy is among the most promising and sustainable sources of renewable energy available today. However, conventional fixed-mount solar panels suffer from a significant drawback: they can capture sunlight efficiently only when the sun is directly aligned with their surface. As the sun's position changes throughout the day and across seasons, a stationary panel loses a substantial portion of potential energy generation.

This project, developed under the discipline of Mechatronics Engineering, presents a smart solar panel system that automatically tracks the sun's position to maximize solar irradiance absorption. Additionally, the system incorporates an active cooling mechanism using a DC fan to dissipate excess heat from the panel surface, counteracting the well-known efficiency degradation that occurs at elevated temperatures.

2. Problem Statement

Fixed solar panels are limited by two fundamental inefficiencies:

- **Angular misalignment:** A stationary panel can only be perpendicular to the sun at one specific time of day. For the remainder of the day, incident solar radiation strikes the surface at a suboptimal angle, reducing power output by 20–40%.
- **Thermal losses:** Solar cells lose approximately 0.4–0.5% efficiency for every 1°C rise above their Standard Test Condition temperature of 25°C. In hot climates or under intense sunlight, panels can exceed 60–70°C, causing significant output degradation.

This project addresses both problems simultaneously through an integrated mechatronic design.

3. Project Objectives

- Design and develop a solar panel mounting system capable of tracking the sun's position automatically.
- Implement a Light Dependent Resistor (LDR) based sensing circuit to detect the direction of maximum sunlight intensity.
- Use a microcontroller to process sensor data and generate appropriate control signals for servo/stepper motors.
- Integrate a DC cooling fan system that activates when the panel temperature exceeds a defined threshold.
- Demonstrate improved energy output compared to a fixed-mount reference panel.
- Build a practical, low-cost prototype suitable for real-world scaling.

4. System Overview

The system is composed of two primary subsystems — the Solar Tracking Subsystem and the Active Cooling Subsystem — both managed by a central microcontroller.

4.1 Solar Tracking Subsystem

Four Light Dependent Resistors (LDRs) are mounted at the four quadrants of the solar panel frame. When sunlight falls unevenly across the LDR array, a voltage differential is created. The microcontroller reads these analog values and determines the direction of greater light intensity. It then commands servo or stepper motors to rotate the panel toward the higher-intensity side. This process runs in a continuous closed-loop, ensuring the panel always faces the sun optimally.

4.2 Active Cooling Subsystem

A temperature sensor (e.g., LM35 or DS18B20) is mounted on the rear of the solar panel. The microcontroller continuously monitors the panel temperature. When the temperature rises above a pre-configured threshold (typically 40–45°C), the microcontroller activates one or more DC cooling fans positioned to blow air across the panel surface. When the temperature drops back to a safe level, the fan is switched off, conserving auxiliary power.

5. Components and Hardware

S/N	Component	Function
1	Arduino Uno / ATmega328P	Central microcontroller for processing and control
2	Solar Panel (6V / 12V)	Primary energy harvesting device
3	LDR Sensors (×4)	Sun direction detection via light intensity comparison
4	Servo Motors / Stepper Motors	Mechanical actuation for panel orientation
5	Temperature Sensor (LM35 / DS18B20)	Real-time panel temperature monitoring
6	DC Cooling Fan(s)	Active heat dissipation from panel surface

7	Motor Driver Module (L298N)	Driving motors with adequate current
8	Relay Module	Switching fan circuit on/off based on temperature
9	Voltage Regulator (7805)	Stable 5V supply for control electronics
10	Chassis / Mounting Frame	Structural support for panel and motors

6. Working Principle

The system operates on a feedback control loop. The four LDR sensors continuously sample ambient light intensity. The microcontroller computes differential values — top vs. bottom and left vs. right — to determine the error angle between the panel's current orientation and the sun's actual position. If the error exceeds a dead-band threshold, the controller drives the motors to correct the orientation. This prevents unnecessary motor activity during negligible light changes (e.g., cloud cover fluctuations).

Simultaneously, the temperature monitoring loop runs independently. The analog temperature reading is compared against a software threshold. If exceeded, a digital output pin drives the relay, energizing the fan circuit. The fan draws air across the panel's rear surface, reducing the operating temperature and recovering lost efficiency. The combined effect of accurate tracking and thermal management results in a measurably higher net energy yield.

7. Expected Results & Benefits

- 10–40% improvement in daily energy yield compared to a fixed-mount panel of identical specifications.
- Panel operating temperature reduced by 8–15°C under active cooling, recovering up to 6% efficiency.
- Autonomous operation without human intervention once deployed.
- Scalable design applicable to residential rooftops, agricultural irrigation pumps, and remote sensor stations.
- Reduced payback period for solar installations due to higher output per unit panel area.

8. Applications

- Residential and commercial rooftop solar installations.
- Remote off-grid power systems (telecom towers, water pumps, weather stations).
- Solar-powered EV charging stations.
- Agricultural solar pumps for irrigation.
- Educational demonstration units for renewable energy labs.

9. Future Scope

- Integration of IoT (Wi-Fi/GSM module) for real-time energy monitoring and remote control via smartphone.
- Addition of a GPS module for astronomical sun-position calculation as a secondary tracking method.
- Machine learning-based predictive tracking using historical weather data.
- Scaling to dual-axis tracking for full azimuth and elevation control.
- Integration with battery management and MPPT charge controllers for a complete off-grid solution.

10. Conclusion

The Dual-Axis Solar Tracker with Active Cooling System is a well-rounded mechatronics project that integrates sensing, actuation, embedded control, and thermal management into a cohesive and practically relevant system. By addressing the two major sources of solar panel inefficiency — angular misalignment and thermal degradation — the project demonstrates a meaningful contribution to the field of renewable energy engineering. The design is cost-effective, implementable with readily available components, and provides a strong foundation for further research and commercial development.

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Submitted by:	Supervised by:
Team Members	Project Supervisor